

## User Generated Content

# Opportunities And Challenges

**O**ur world would be a very boring place, if we all agreed all the time. We also know that letting people express their views freely, has real practical benefits. Allowing individuals to voice unpopular, inconvenient or controversial opinions is also important. Not only might they be right (think Galileo), but debating difficult issues in the open often helps people come to better decisions.

India, the world's largest democracy, faces challenges unlike any other nation on earth. I'm often asked if online companies are helping or complicating the collective conversation, that is democracy in India. I would, absolutely, say it's helping. But no one should deceive themselves—it's complicated, as well.

While most people acknowledge the right to free expression, the challenge, however, is putting theory to practice. And that certainly holds true on the Web—to speak and be heard as never before.

We are witnessing an explosion of content online. With increasing numbers getting faster Internet connections (though still not enough in India), cheaper digital storage and lower production costs for music, videos and Web sites—the rules for social communications have fundamentally changed.

The result is the democratisation of access information and the ability to communicate. Individuals can create and find information, communicating directly with one another, without having to pass through the bottlenecks of traditional institutional controls.

At Google, we have a bias in favour of people's right to free expression in everything we do. But we also recognise that freedom of expression can't be—and shouldn't be—without some limits. The difficulty is in deciding where these boundaries are drawn. For a company like ours, with services in more than 100 countries with differing laws and cultural norms, it's a challenge we face often.

In a few cases, it's straightforward. While child pornography is illegal in virtually every country, for political extremism it's not as simple. Some countries' histories make commentary or criticism on certain topics that are especially sensitive. Other countries believe that the best way to discredit extremists is to allow their arguments to be publicly exposed.

People have different views about what should appear on our sites. How and where to draw the boundaries is the subject of lively debate, even within Google. We think that's healthy. And partly because of this—we realise that creating a flawless set of policies on which everyone can agree is an impossible task.

The most challenging areas are where we host other people's content. On the one hand, we're not generating the content and we aim to offer a platform for free expression. On the other hand, we host the content on our servers and want to be socially responsible. So we have terms that we ask our users to follow. See Blogger and Orkut for example.

How do we enforce these terms? We, at Google, don't believe in being the gatekeeper, and can't



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check content before it goes live, in the same way that your phone company wouldn't screen the content of your phone calls or your ISP wouldn't edit your e-mails. We also have millions of active users who are vocal when it comes to alerting us on content that they find unacceptable or believe, may breach our policies. When they do, we review it and remove it appropriately. These are always subjective judgments and some people will inevitably disagree. But that's because what's acceptable to one person may be offensive to another.

We also face the added complication that laws governing online content apply differently in the different parts of the world we operate in. These legal differences create real technical challenges. In extreme cases, we face questions about whether a country's laws and lack of democratic processes are so antithetical to our principles that we simply can't comply or operate there in a way that benefits users.

Dealing with controversial content is one of the biggest challenges we face as a company. We do try hard to think things through from first principles, to be as transparent as possible about how we make decisions, and to keep reviewing and debating our policies. After all, the right to disagree is a sign of a healthy society.

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